

ENTRY MANAGEMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

ENTRY MANAGEMENT LESSON

There may be nothing more frustrating in Bridge than looking across at dummy and seeing three good tricks sitting there - and you have no way to reach them.

Entry Management may sound classy, but it just means being in the right place at the right time.

Plan Early and Wisely:

The contract is 3NT and West leads the ♠7.

♠ A 8 3 2

♥ A J 6 4

♦ A Q 5 3

♣ A



♠ K 6

♥ 7 5 3

♦ 6 4 2

♣ K Q J 10 3

If you play low from dummy you will be forced to win your ♠K immediately, or at trick 2 after East wins trick 1 and returns another ♠.

Now you will go down because after unblocking dummy's ♣A you have no entry back to your hand.

You may have planned early, but you didn't play wisely. The contract is absolutely cold as long as you win the first trick with dummy's ♠A. Then you unblock the ♣A and you still have the ♠K entry to your hand.

Simple enough, right? Just use common sense and think **before** you play, not after.

And the good news is that most of the entry problems you encounter will be just that easy to solve.

But there are a few tougher cases, and a few strategies to get around them, which is why you decided to read this lesson.

Cheap Tricks, and when not to take them:

Bridge players realize early that it is obviously a good idea to win a trick with the smallest card that they can, thereby keeping their higher cards for later. It's hard to ignore that principle, even when you should.

Here's another 3NT contract. (Yes, Bridge writers love to use 3NT contracts.)

West leads the ♠3. East plays a low ♠.

♠ Q J 10
 ♥ 7 3
 ♦ K J 10 9 8
 ♣ 8 6 4

Suppose you let dummy's ♠10 win the trick.
 When you try to establish the ♦ suit East will take the second ♦ and return a ♠.

If you play low from your hand West will take the ♠A and play another ♠ to your ♠K.
 You will never reach dummy's good ♦s.

♠ K 7 5
 ♥ A Q 3 2
 ♦ Q 5
 ♣ A K 7 2

If instead you play your ♠K when East leads that second ♠ West will allow your ♠K to hold the trick.
 You will never reach dummy's good ♦s.

It is easy to now see where things went wrong.
 Get your ♠K out of the way by using it to win the first trick and dummy's ♠ Q J will guarantee an entry to the ♦ suit.

Unblocking intermediate cards:

Sometimes a hand looks so simple that you don't spot the danger until too late.

The contract is 6NT. West leads the ♠6.
 East takes the ♠A and returns the ♠J.

♠ 5 3 2
 ♥ 6 2
 ♦ 8 5 4
 ♣ A K Q 5 3

This looks like a cinch as long as the ♣s don't split 4-0.

You win the second trick with your ♠K, play the ♣4 to dummy's ♣Q, and breathe a sigh of relief when both defenders follow suit (it turns out they split 3-1).

♠ K 7 4
 ♥ A K Q
 ♦ A K Q
 ♣ 8 7 6 4

A few minutes later that sigh of relief turns into a cry of anguish when you discover that you can only win 4 ♣ tricks because after taking ♣ A K Q you will take the next ♣ in your hand!

Try it again from trick 2. This time play the ♣8 to dummy's ♣Q, and play the ♣7 and ♣6 under the ♣K and ♣A. Then, when you play dummy's ♣5 you can slip your ♣4 underneath it!

Overtaking to save an entry:

There is another way the sacrifice of a high card may pay off as an entry.

The contract is 3NT. West leads the ♠Q.

♠ 6
 ♥ 8 4 3
 ♦ A Q 10 9 8 7
 ♣ K 5



♠ A K 4 2
 ♥ A 7 6 2
 ♦ K
 ♣ A 8 6 4

Outside the ♦ suit you have 5 winners and no chance of creating any more.

So you need to get at least 4 ♦ tricks.

Suppose you win the first trick, play your ♦K, then go to dummy with the ♣K and start running the ♦s. All will be well if they split 3-3 but a 4-2 split is more likely with one defender holding ♦ J x x x.

Now try it this way. Win the first trick, play your ♦K, **OVERTAKE IT WITH THE ♦A**, then continue with ♦Q, ♦10. Somebody will win their ♦J but you still have that precious ♣K dummy entry to those other good ♦s.

The ♦K was worth more as an entry than it was as a high card.

Finessing for an entry:

That title doesn't sound like much of a daring strategy - of course there are times when you will have to finesse to get the entry you need.

Ahh, but here we are talking about a finesse that would otherwise be completely unnecessary, one which, if it loses, will actually throw a sure trick away.

The contract is 6♣. West leads the ♥Q.

♠ K Q 9 7 6 3
 ♥ 6 4 2
 ♦ A J
 ♣ 4 2



♠ --
 ♥ A K 5 3
 ♦ K 8
 ♣ A K Q J 9 8 7

You have 2 ♥ losers. A 3-3 split in the suit would allow you to set up your fourth ♥ but West's opening lead makes you think he probably has 4 or 5 ♥s.

You decide you must establish some ♠ tricks in dummy, but you need two entries for that play, one to get over there the first time and the second to get back after you have dislodged their ♠A. Unfortunately you have only one sure entry, the ♦A.

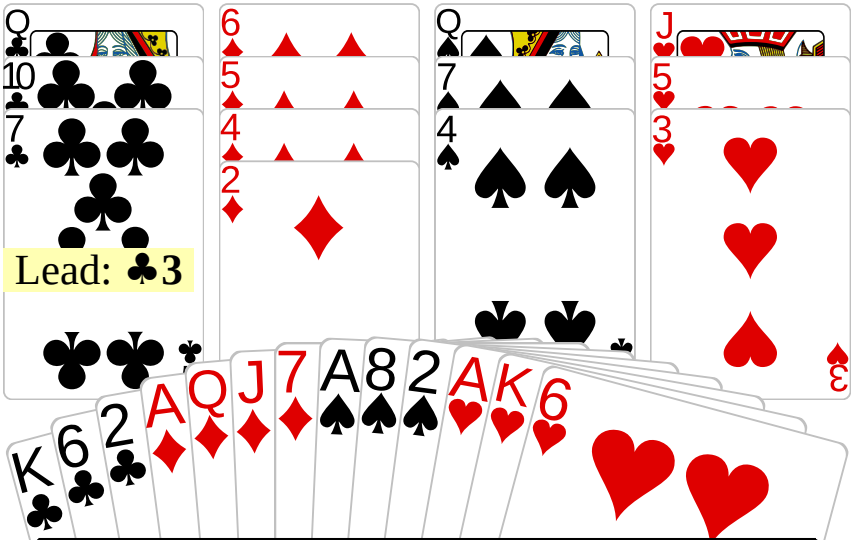
Win the first trick. Pull trumps in 2 or 3 rounds. Play a small ♦ and when West plays low finesse the ♦J - the unnecessary finesse. Today it wins. Now play the ♠K and when East plays a low card discard a ♥ loser. West can win the ♠A but you win his return, enter dummy with the ♦A and discard your other ♥ loser on the ♠Q.

Now ask yourself this: How good would West have to be to put his ♦Q on your first ♦ play to deprive you of that entry? Pretty good, I'd say.

There are other scenarios, many involving the sacrifice of a winner to gain an entry, and while we could go on and on and on . . .

. . . 20 examples should be worth more than another 2000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



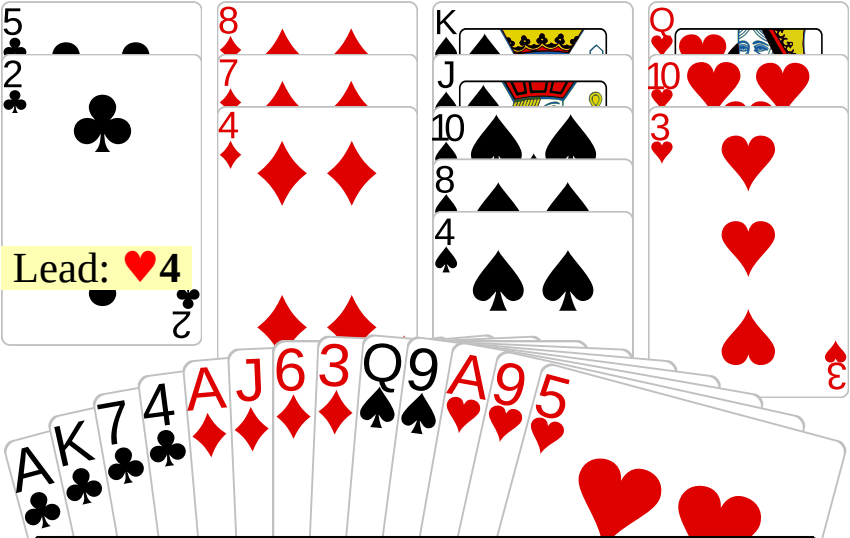
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



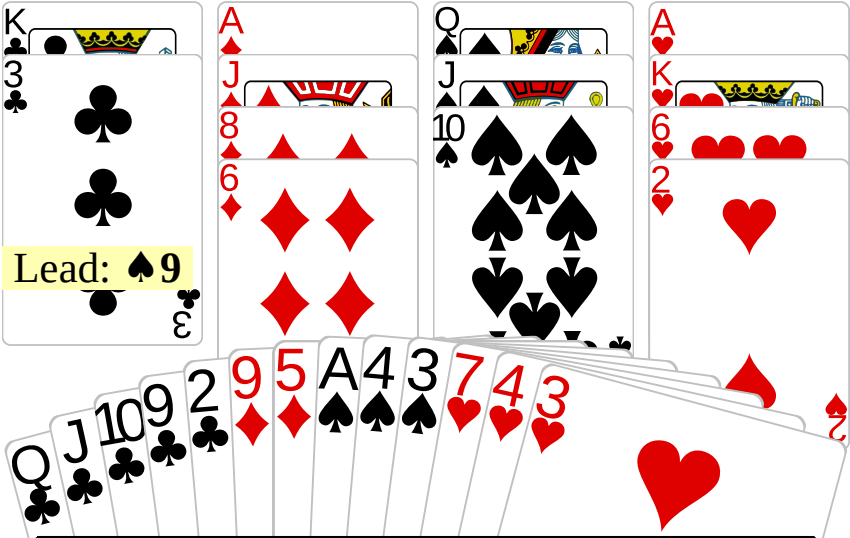
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



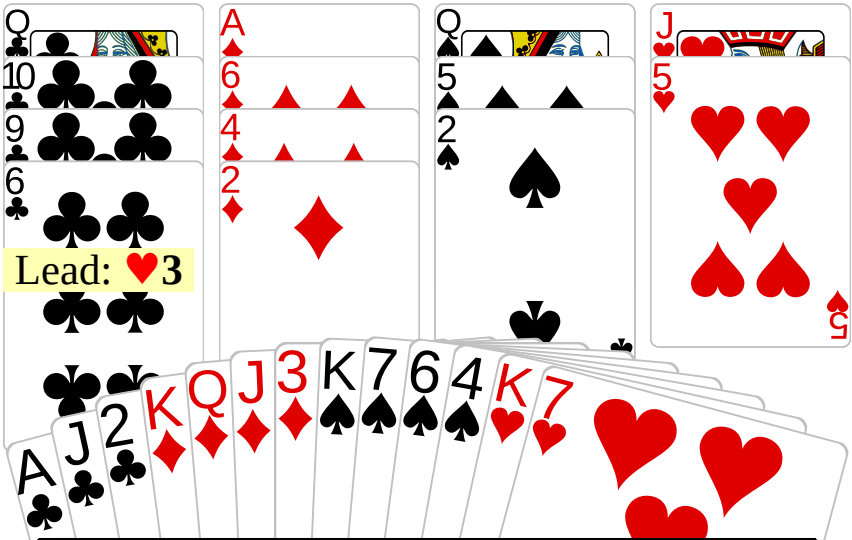
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♣3

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Lead: ♦5

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Lead: ♥4

Board: 4

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: West

Lead: ♠9

Board: 5

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♥3

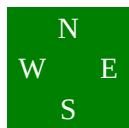
Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ K J 9
♥ 10 9 8 2
♦ K 9 3
♣ A 8 4

♠ A 8 2
♥ A K 6
♦ A Q J 7
♣ K 6 2



♠ 10 6 5 3
♥ Q 7 4
♦ 10 8
♣ J 9 5 3

♠ Q 7 4
♥ J 5 3
♦ 6 5 4 2
♣ Q 10 7

West	North	East	South
	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♣3			

play a ♣ to dummy's ♣10. Lead a ♦ and finesse the ♦J, which holds. Play another ♣ to dummy and finesse another ♦. Now play your ♦A and smile when the ♦K drops and your fourth ♦ becomes a winner.

As soon as West put up the ♣A you knew you could win 2 ♣ tricks.

By unblocking the ♣K you were still pretty confident that you would get the two tricks, but the bonus was in the extra dummy entry your unblock created.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♣3, West plays the ♣A.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 6

You have the possibility of one additional ♠ winner if East holds the ♠K. However, ♦s is your best suit and if West holds the ♦K you could gain all three winners that you need from that suit. But of course you need perhaps 2 dummy entries. Do you have them?

Well, you probably do. East's small ♣ lead probably indicates an honor, and with West playing the ♣A you can be pretty sure that East holds the ♣J. So by playing your ♣K underneath the ♣A you set up a second entry to dummy via the ♣ finesse.

Assume West now plays a ♥. Take your ♥A and

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q J
 ♥ A Q 6
 ♦ 8 4
 ♣ Q J 9 8 5 3

♠ A 6 4
 ♥ 9 7 4 2
 ♦ Q 10 6
 ♣ K 7 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 10 9 8 3
 ♥ K J
 ♦ K 7 3
 ♣ A 10 2

♠ 7 5 2
 ♥ 10 8 5 3
 ♦ A J 9 5 2
 ♣ 6

West	North	East	South
		1 ♠	Pass
2 ♣	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			
3NT by East			
Lead: ♦ 5			

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♦ 5, North plays the ♦ Q.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=3 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 5

You must take the ♦ K right now or you might lose the first 5 tricks.

It's a shame about that solid ♠ suit, but if you try to win even a single ♠ they will grab the ♠ A and win enough ♦ tricks to set the contract.

So you are going to have to win a lot of ♣ tricks, and do so without losing the lead. You need dummy entries, and they must be in ♥s.

Win the ♦ K. Play the ♥ J to dummy's ♥ Q. Play the ♣ Q and when North follows with a low card let it ride. Still in dummy, play the ♣ J, again letting it ride when North plays low. Play one more ♣ to your ♣ A, picking up North's ♣ K this time.

The ♣ suit is ready to run, so play your ♥ K to dummy's ♥ A and take your ♣ winners. You took 9 tricks in all, the ♦ K, the ♥ A Q and all 6 ♣s.

You started with 3 ♥ winners, but had to sacrifice one of them to get the second entry to dummy.

Since it gave you all 6 ♣ tricks the sacrifice was well worth it.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

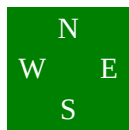
♠ 6 3
♥ K J 7 4 2
♦ Q 10
♣ 10 9 8 3

♠ K J 10 8 4

♥ Q 10 3

♦ 8 7 4

♣ 5 2



♠ A 7 5 2
♥ 8 6
♦ K 9 5 2
♣ Q J 6

♠ Q 9

♥ A 9 5

♦ A J 6 3

♣ A K 7 4

West	North	East	South
			1 ♦
Pass	1 ♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♥ 4			

♥ Q.

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥ 4, you play low in dummy and East plays the ♥ 8.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 5

The winners list looks a little skimpy, but what a nice solid ♠ suit. It will be a cinch to establish 4 winners in the suit - if only you have an entry to reach them.

You are probably getting good at this by now. The way to make sure of a dummy entry is to pass up the Cheap Trick ♥ 9 and win the first trick with the ♥ A. Since East did not play third-hand-high he probably doesn't have a high card to play. You are confident that West has led from the ♥ K so by taking the ♥ A at once you guarantee you can get back to dummy when you need to do so.

After you win the ♥ A you start on ♠ s, and they hold-up their ♠ A for one round. But you can get to dummy and the rest of the ♠ s by leading toward the

On these pages there have been many deals where you had to win the opening lead with an unnecessarily high card in order to create a later entry to dummy.

Here's a question: How many times at the table have situations like this presented themselves but you didn't realize it? And of course, at the table there is no second page popping up to tell you what you should have done.

Board 4

East Deals

Both Vul

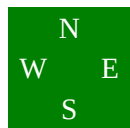
♠ A 4 3
 ♥ 7 4 3
 ♦ 9 5
 ♣ Q J 10 9 2

♠ 9 8 7 6 5

♥ Q 8

♦ K 10 3

♣ 8 6 4



♠ Q J 10
 ♥ A K 6 2
 ♦ A J 8 6
 ♣ K 3

♠ K 2

♥ J 10 9 5

♦ Q 7 4 2

♣ A 7 5

West	North	East	South
		1 ♦	Pass
1NT	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			
3NT by West			
Lead: ♠ 9			

West is to play 3NT. North leads the ♠ 9, and South plays the ♠ K.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 6

I'll bet you got this one. The extra ♣ tricks you need are winnable only if you can get back to your hand after knocking out the ♣ A. But the only possible entry card is the ♠ A. If you use it on the first trick the Defense will hold up their ♣ A for one trick and your hand will be shot..

So let South keep the first trick, (sacrificing one ♠ winner), and take the next ♠ in dummy. Then establish ♣ s.

You sacrifice one ♠ trick for four ♣ tricks. A good deal.

Yet another variation on the theme.

There are two basic types; one where you give up a winner to gain an entry, and this type where you get the entry without giving up a thing.

It looks a little different, but the theme is the same. PROTECT YOUR ENTRY.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ A 10 8 3
♥ Q 9 6 4
♦ 10 8
♣ K 7 3

♠ K 7 6 4

♥ K 7

♦ K Q J 3

♣ A J 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ J 9

♥ A 10 8 3 2

♦ 9 7 5

♣ 8 5 4

♠ Q 5 2

♥ J 5

♦ A 6 4 2

♣ Q 10 9 6

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♥3			

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥3, you play dummy's ♥J and West plays the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=4 ♣=1 Total = 6

Unless you want to go down really, really early you had better take your ♥K right now. And unless you want to go down almost as early you'd better stay completely away from the ♠ suit. So that only leaves you the ♣ suit to get 3 more winners in. West will have to have ♣K so you can finesse it. You are also going to have to be smart with entries. Got it?

If West has just ♣K x then one finesse, followed by the ♣A to drop the ♣K and a small ♣ back to dummy will give you the 4 ♣ winners you must have. But if West has ♣K x x and refuses to cover then you will be able to establish the ♣s but will need an extra dummy entry to enjoy that last winner.

So win the ♥K and play the ♦K Q. If both defenders follow suit you can afford to overtake your ♦J with dummy's ♦A. Now play the ♣10 and let it ride. If it holds the trick play another ♣ to your ♣J and then play the ♣A, dropping West's ♣K.

Enter dummy by playing your ♦3 to the ♦6 and take your established ♣ for the ninth trick.

Suppose a defender showed out on the second ♦.

With only one outside entry to dummy your choices are limited.

You might play West for ♣K x and lead a small to your ♣J, then play ♣A.

Or you might try leading the ♣Q hoping that West will see this as a time to "cover an honor with an honor".